Life in Eden

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Bachelor Of Fine Arts
Thesis / Class of 2020

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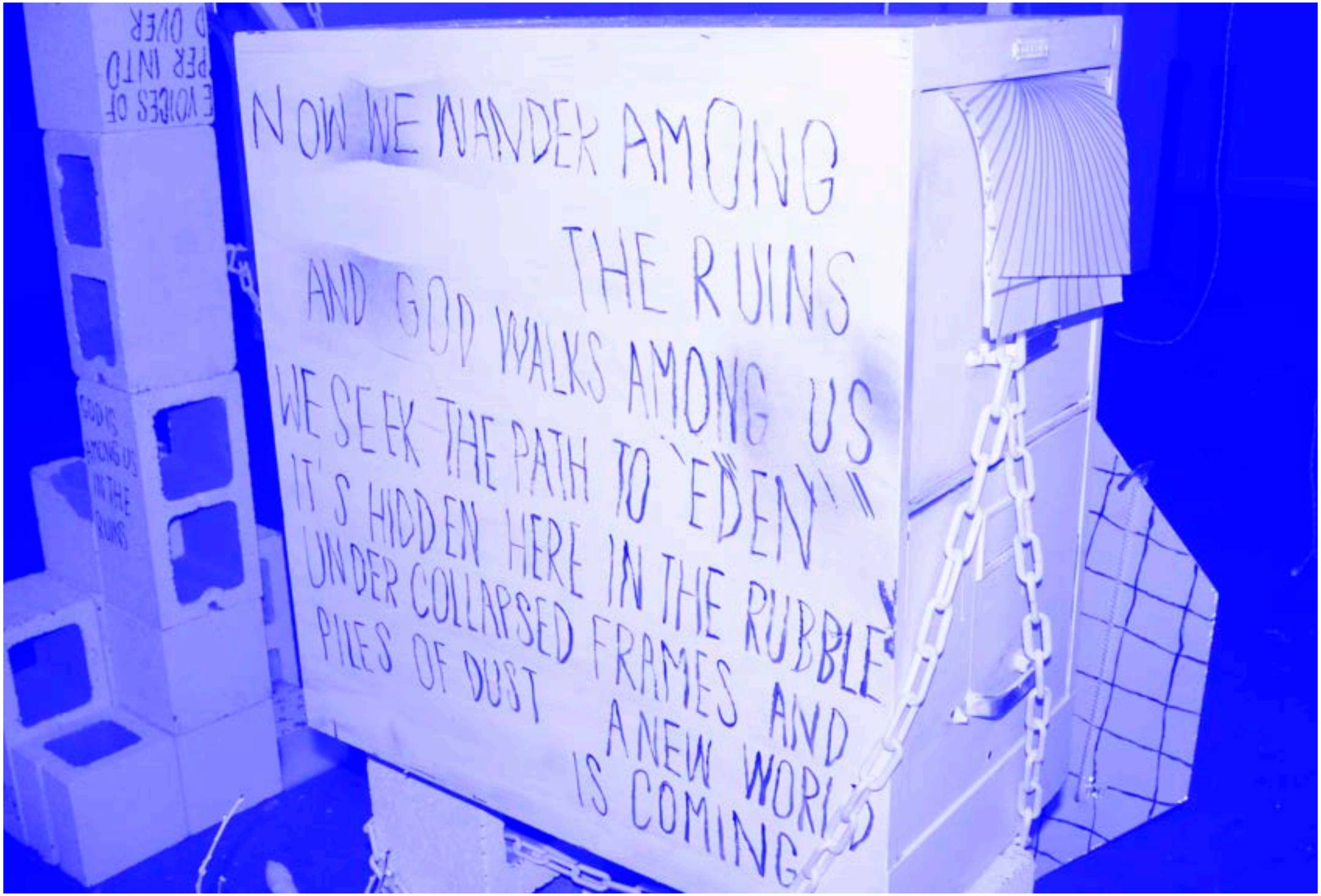

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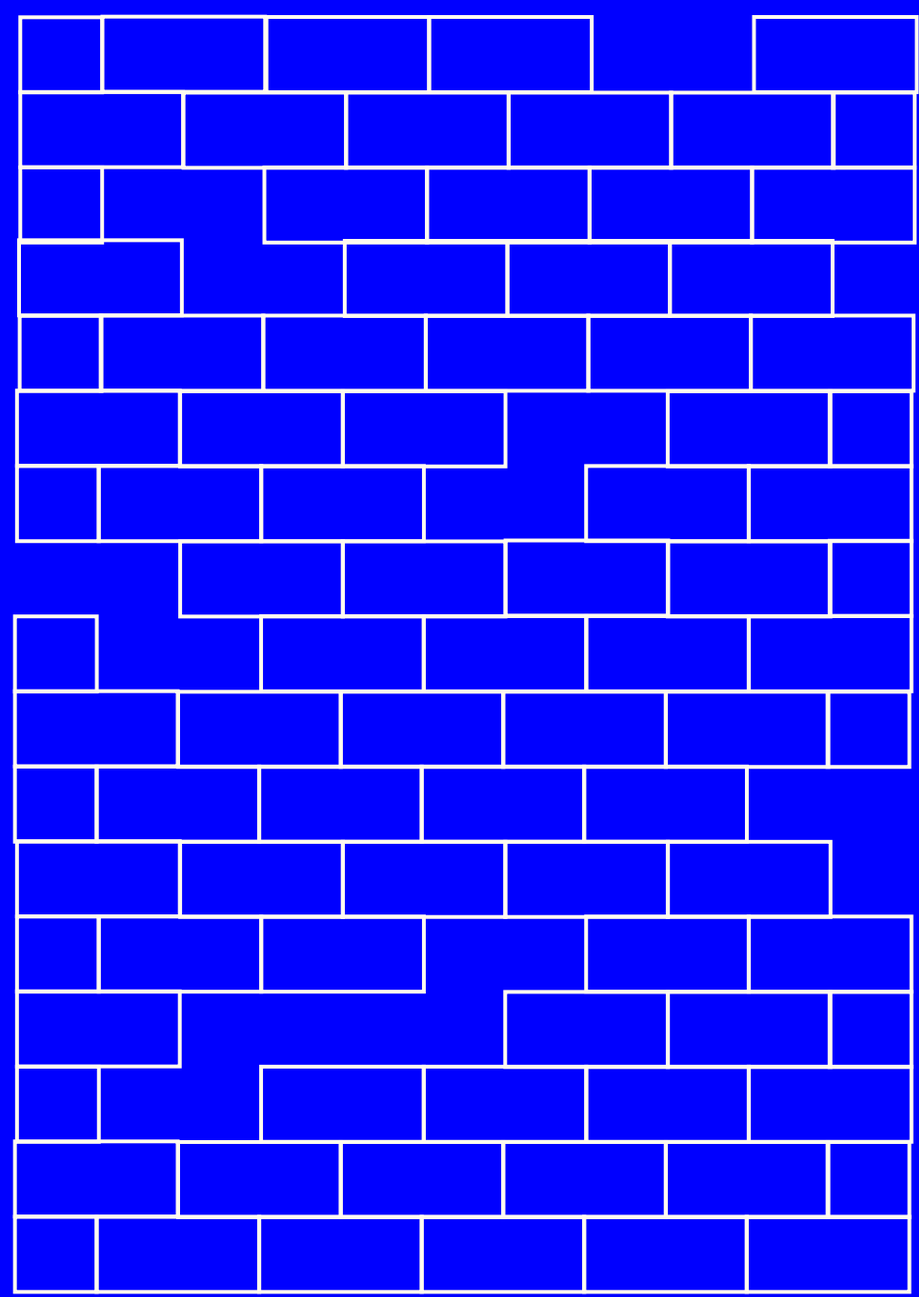

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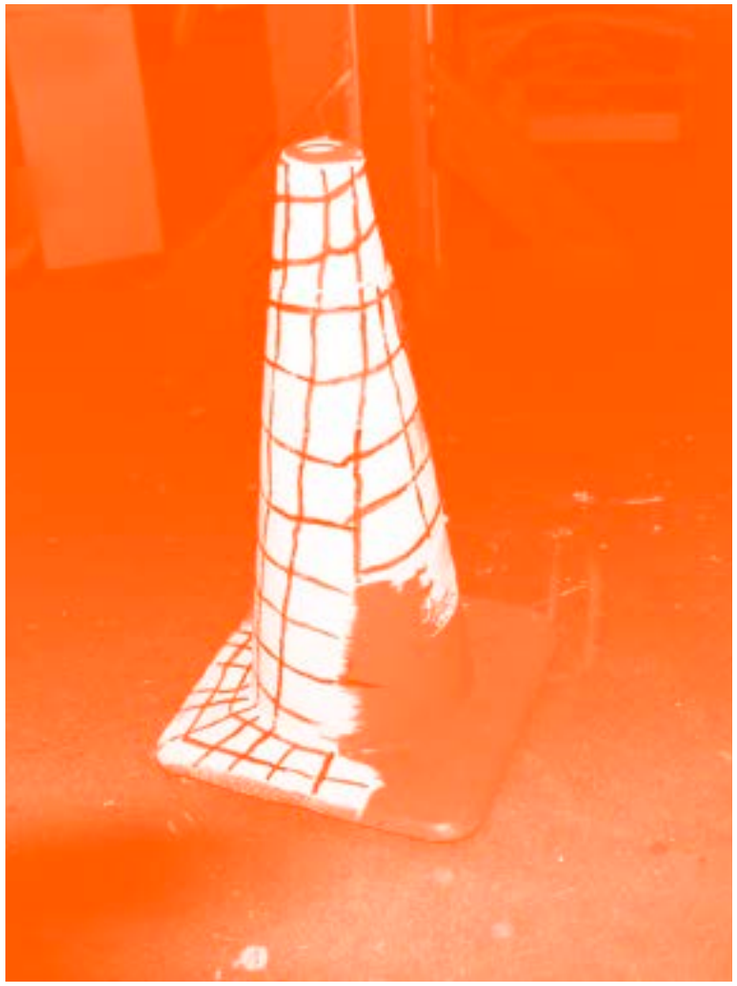
PART ONE

WALLS



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In *Manufacturing Consent*, Noam Chomsky develops in length the theory of over-information. Modern media assaults us with a constant stream of reports on the world's social and political ills, which in theory would lead to an empowered public. In reality, he explains, the opposite is true: by constantly exposing us to the system's injustice, it numbs us to it. Injustice becomes a background noise, a mundane fact of our existence. We are gently nudged into a state of learned helplessness, which is difficult to escape.

LIFE IN EDEN, my thesis work, does not offer to fix the system - it does not even offer a straightforward political message. Rather, it is about my personal quest to put myself in a state of non-helplessness. My final aim as an artist is to develop and present the vision (however blurry) of a counter-current, an alternative to the present state of things.

Outside of me the world is raging. Thanks to my constant and uncontrolled exposure to social media, I am well aware of just how much is going on. In faraway lands, some people my age are fighting

revolutions - while others, also my age, fight to crush these revolutions. Terrorist cells get formed, militias get organized, assassinations are carried out. Around the globe, mega-corporations are plotting, restructuring, destabilizing. Their complex schemes generate billions of dollars within minutes, which they burn through just as fast. Governments rise and collapse, fortunes are made and erased, crowds of people take over the streets before a few bullets disperse them. This right here is the epic ballet of history, the great musical of global politics. Where do I, Raphael Lewi, fit into this ? Nowhere, it seems. You won't see my name on the poster. Despite my best efforts, I did not make the cast.

I was born in Paris, France - a global metropolis of 10+ million residents from every possible background. Some, in the city's eastern outskirts (home to the immigrant-heavy neighborhoods, and also where I grew up), participate in global networks of drug or sex trafficking. On the other end, the west side's luxury condos are inhabited by Fortune 500 CEOs, pop music prodigies, and fashion superstars. Paris is where I developed my sense of scale, and mostly, it made me feel small. I wasn't born, it seemed, to play a part in the grand scheme of history. Instead, my

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future was to be a cog within a cog within a cog - a tiny node in the hegemonic network maintained by neoliberal capitalism. I, the node, receive an input and produce an output - labour (through work) and culture (through art). With this, I do my part in maintaining and growing the western neoliberal economy. Economic instability (which just comes with being an artist, it seems) keeps me in check - in a world that's constantly on the verge of crisis, the most I can hope for is that I'll keep my job and be able to pay rent. I am stuck in place, blocked between four walls. When I lend an ear to the metaphorical walls, I can hear the rage and furor of neoliberalism's endless war against itself. But that war is happening in the background, muted behind the wall. I can witness it, but not get involved.

My concerns are getting to work on time, remembering to call my parents every two days, and bringing kosher wine to the Kiddush on Friday nights.

"The flipside of liberal ideas of freedom—namely, the freedom of corporations from any form of regulation, as well as the freedom to relentlessly pursue one's own interest at the expense of everyone else's—has become the only form of universal freedom that exists: the freedom from social bonds, freedom from solidarity, freedom from certainty or predictability, freedom from employment or labor, freedom from culture, public transport, education, or anything public at all. [...]

As Janis Joplin sang, "Freedom's just another word for nothing left to lose." This is the freedom that people in many places share today. Contemporary freedom is not primarily the enjoyment of civil liberties, as the traditional liberal view has it, but rather like the freedom of free fall, experienced by many who are thrown into an uncertain and unpredictable future."

Hito Steyerl - Freedom From Everything: Freelancers and Mercenaries

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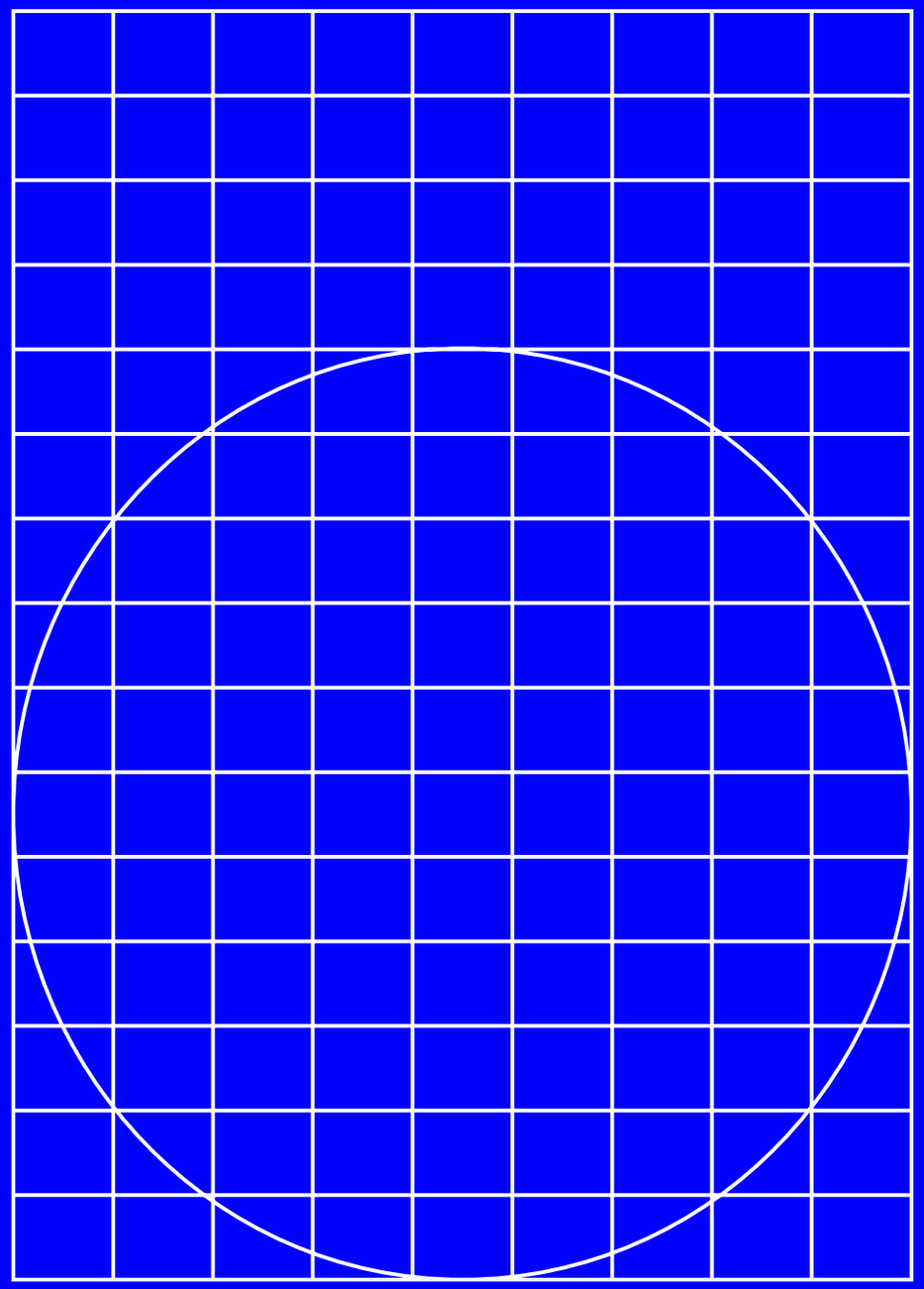

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PART TWO

HEGE-MONY

As an emerging artist, I'm often expected to describe what my work is about in a split second. I come back to a quote[1] from Frederic Jameson, a prominent 20th century marxist theorist:

"It is easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism."

My art practice, I'd say snarkily, is about imagining both of them.

Jameson's quote is an indirect reference to the writing of another philosopher, Francis Fukuyama. Fukuyama is also a prominent 20th-century writer, but on the other side of the political spectrum - he was instrumental to the rise of the neoconservative movement. In the final years of the 1990's, as the communist superpower was being ripped apart, Fukuyama proclaimed that mankind had entered its final period: the End of History, an era in which we've reached "the end-point of mankind's ideological evolution and the universalization of Western liberal democracy as the final form of human government." What he is describing here in his own (positive) terms is what I personally describe as the neo-liberal hegemony.

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Neo-liberalism is a hotly-debated term with multiple definitions. To me, it is first of all an ideology, which encompasses a wide list of "neoliberal" values - faith in the free market, faith in capitalism, private property over public property, globalism over localism, technology over spirituality, disruption over tradition.
Neo-liberalism is also the worldwide system that's been built to enforces that ideology, sometimes violently. I particularly like the theoretical model laid out by Tiqqun[2], in which neo-liberalism is the fusion of two complementary oppressive forces: soft power and violent power. Soft power molds the mind, violent power enforces submission. The two powers protect and legitimize each other. They are the media power and military power. The entertainer and the cop. MTV and FBI. The society of the spectacle and the society of surveillance.

Fukuyama saw the End of History as mankind's crowning achievement. In his view, all human history amounts to a massive, tragic conflict. The End of History, then, is the closing chapter of this conflict: finally, mankind was united under the banner of liberal democracy, and can now progress towards a perfect utopia.

My view is... different. While I totally agree with Fukuyama that the world today is ruled by neo-liberal hegemony, this is everything but a happy ending to me. In my view this hegemony is not the structure of an utopia, but instead a global system of repression and alienation.

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I grew up in the mid-90's, in the aftermath of the Berlin Wall collapsing. Fukuyama's End of History, as described in Part Three of this essay, happened almost in conjunction with my birth - you could say that my life took place 'post-History'. I did not bare witness to the competition of two opposing ideologies. All my life, whether in France or in the United States, I have been under the total subjugation of the Western neoliberal hegemony. I do belong to a privileged class, which partially protects me from the most overtly oppressive elements of the system. And yet, a life lived under neo-liberalism will always be a life of fundamental dispossession: I live in a land I don't own, under the governance of a detached plutocracy, and within infrastructures that I have no control over. As long as I live within this landscape, my agency will always be subjugated by these infrastructures.

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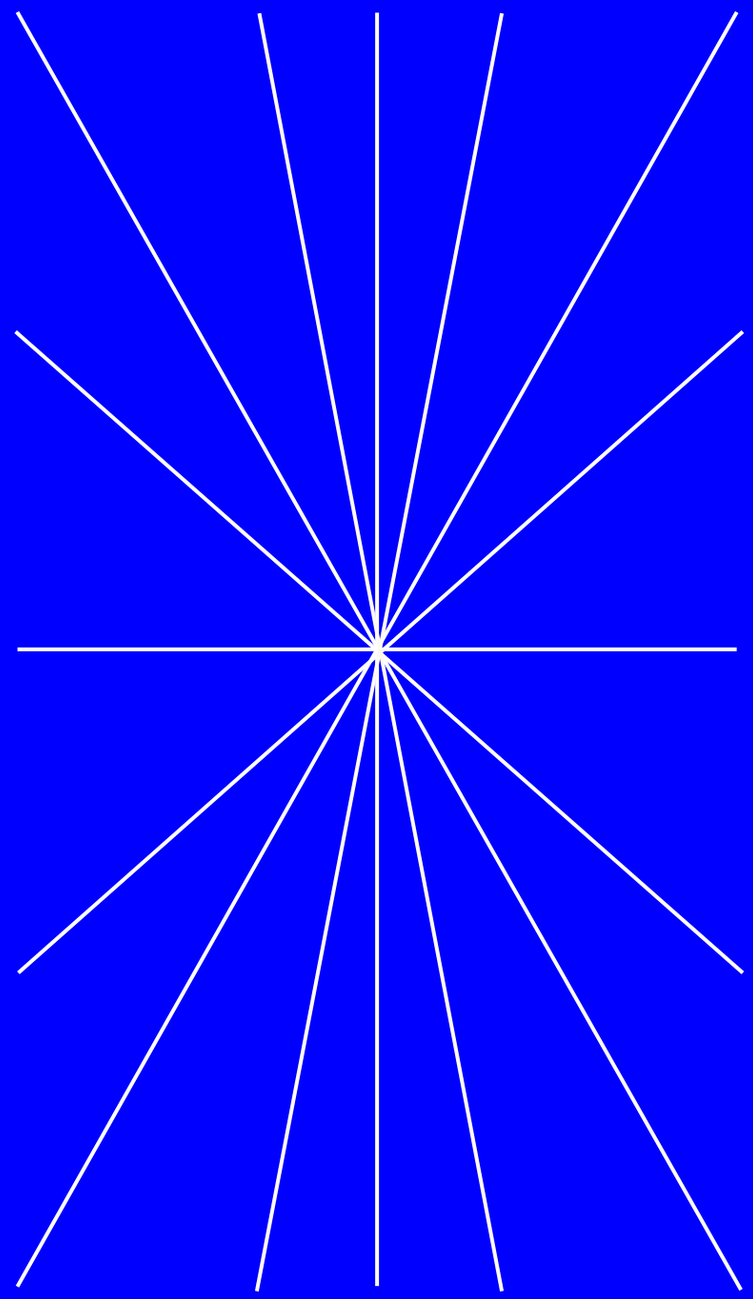

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PART THREE

UTOPIAS

June 2019. The spring semester has just ended, campus is closed. And it's only now that I can process how utterly lost I am. The school that I have been studying at for two years - the school that I've moved to Portland for - has shut its doors forever. Our dean had tearfully announced the decision a few months ago, but it had not quite hit me like it does now. It's summer, and I am stuck in an intermission. Stuck between two years, two schools, two studios. Since for the next two months I am denied a space to work in, I find refuge in reading - wandering through the library, randomly picking books based on their cover. Among them is a bulky encyclopedia-like yellow book, which seems misplaced in the art section. On the front cover is a burning geodesic dome[3], and the book's title: Hippie Modernism - The Struggle For Utopia.

This book (which accompanied an eponymous exhibition at the Walker Art Center) would become my companion throughout my thesis. It tells with great details the stories of the Cold War artists/designers who worked - simultaneously and throughout the world - to build their own personal version of a future utopia. Despite the time difference, the theme was extremely relevant to my current feelings: this move-

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ment was a direct reaction to neo-liberalism taking hold as an ideology in the 60's. Radical creatives, disillusioned with the socio-economic direction that their society was taking, deployed art and design as tools to create hippie universes - alternative and speculative utopias free from war, capitalism, and mass-entertainment.

The creative groups presented in Hippie Modernism go into vastly different directions: the Cockettes, in San Francisco, performed a theatrical world free from the constraints of class and gender; Ken Isaacs invented futuristic structures with no solid walls, made for a new nomadic lifestyle; the Drop City folks built and organised a communal farm that served as a haven for artists and free-thinkers. Out of these many groups, the one that stood out most to me was the Italian design collective Superstudio. Superstudio - founded in 1966 by Adolfo Natalini - was an experimental architecture and furniture studio that rejected mundane corporate works and instead followed a personal quest to develop and realize the founders' radical, world-transforming

vision. Whereas many hippie artists adopted aesthetics that were colorful and maximalist, the work of Superstudio's vision for the future was deliberately stripped down to the extreme (a choice that I would eventually follow). The foundation for all of their work was a perfectly square black & white grid that spread in all directions and can scale infinitely - at small scale, it becomes a pattern for a dress; at large scale, it covers our planet.

Superstudio did produce functional objects, such as cloths and benches, that were based on this grid. But their real objective was a purely aspirational, utopian project: to manifest a holistic vision of the world, which the grid is a blueprint for. Everything is on the grid, and the grid contains everything. Absolute equality. Absolute unity, Absolute interconnectivity. A new, modern metaphor for heaven.

Superstudio's master plan, which remains a fantasy, is made concrete in their video series Five Fundamental Acts. Each of the Acts is one short educational film, and presents a radical program to transform the five essential aspects of our human experience: Life, Education, Ceremony, Love, Death.

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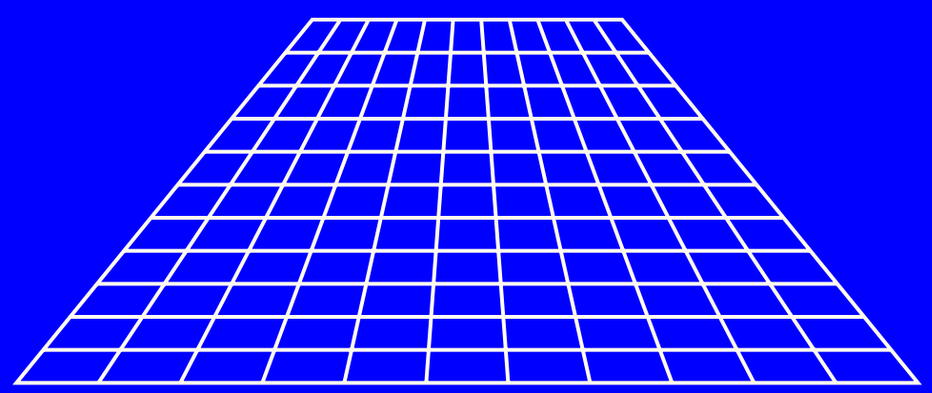

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PART FOUR

PLAY-GROUND

Like Superstudio, my answer to the modern world was to reclaim my agency by building a fictional future, a new reality where the neo-liberal infrastructure no longer exists. This world manifests itself as 'Eden', which is the speculative future that all of my work "lives" in. It also manifests itself as my studio space - the space that my work literally lives in.

My 'Eden' is a fictional version of our world in which western civilization has entirely collapsed - an event that I refer to as the Downfall. The exact circumstances of the Downfall remain obscure. Was it a divine Tabula Rasa, as foretold by the Old Testament ? Or was it the logical endpoint of the social and economic tensions that we are experiencing today ?

Eden shares similarities with its biblical namesake: it is a permanent wilderness, free from man-made structures. Within the rubble, all the resources and materials from the past civilization are still there and up for grabs - for the few inhabitants of Eden, survival is not a concern. However, there are no goals, rules, or hierarchies. It is a free territory, a sandbox for the surviving humans to play in. Eden represents my idea of what a better future (if not ideal future) could look like. It is the mapped-out alternative to

the current issues I was describing earlier. in Eden, all land is uncharted and ownerless; all people govern themselves; each one builds infrastructures as they see fit.

In my personal search for an alternative world, creating the fictional world of Eden was an important first step - but not the last. No, it would not be enough to simply imagine a make-believe world. My goal as an artist was to separate myself from an alienated, helpless lifestyle. To do so, I had to bring Eden to life. I've said that in the outside world I feel mostly without agency. However there is one place where I get to have all the agency: my studio space. My art studio, wherever it is physically located, is the 'actual' space of free-form agency that mirrors Eden's 'fantastical' space of free-form agency. In simple terms, I get to treat my studio as if it was a playground. Whereas in the outside world I constantly feel constrained and alienated, the studio is my designated space to play and explore haptic experiments. I'd note that this search for "haptic knowledge" is a direct take-away from the craft education I've received, even though

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my work has little to do with traditional craft. I assemble, construct, deconstruct, seal together, break open. I build structures using clay, concrete, wood, and whatever interesting object I could find on the street. My artistic space is a messy arrangement of rubble, as is Eden. While working in the studio, I fashion myself into a fictional alter-ego: the Keeper, my counterpart in Eden. The Keeper is a lone survivor of the Downfall who has left behind his past identity and roams the ruins of the old world. With scavenged scraps as his material, he creates sculptures imbued with a spiritual symbolism (the following chapter expands on this). He and I live in overlapping dimensions, separated by a porous membrane: every art-object made in my studio is something that exists, as a totem made by the Keeper, somewhere in the ruins of Eden.

My art is always open-ended - I never come to the studio with an exact course of action in mind. Instead I simply take a few of my materials and make intuitive moves, keeping in mind the narrative of Eden. I am careful to start from a limited set of elements: in

my thesis work, you will note a restrained palette of colors, shapes, and images. I've taken that cue from the work of Superstudio, although I've always had a tendency towards simple and bold art. Restraint allows for a more coherent body of work; it prevents the artist from getting lost in minor details; and it encourages an iterative process where each element becomes more refined with each pass .

The acts of gluing, painting, forming, spraying, slowly add up to create "a piece".
I sit back to look at what I've created -
Does it evoke an interesting story ?
Does it fit, and does it further, the world-building of Eden ?
Are the formal qualities strong and coherent ?
Does it look cool ?

If the piece speaks to me, I will keep it in my studio and refine it further. Eventually I would use it for a final work presented to the public (although by that time, it may have changed significantly). And what, then, about the pieces that don't speak to me ? Some have to be thrown away, but most get broken down and turned into something else. Broken beams laying in my studio - I was trying to build a ladder,

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which collapsed as soon as I climbed the first step - became the basis for another sculpture: a wooden antenna, to communicate with the powers that lie above. This new work, the Antenna to Heaven, is now an integral part of my thesis. Keeping with the idea of a playground, there is no failure in my studio. I am fending off helplessness as long as i am making things.

Using materials that are cheap or free gives me the option to work 'carelessly', which is one element in reclaiming my agency. And because my pieces are replaceable, I do not have to treat them like precious objects. Quite the opposite: I am constantly shifting things around in my space. Items go on the wall, on the floors, on the ceiling. After some time, they'll get stacked and imbricated into more complex "gestalt" structures.

This process of gestalt happens on two levels. On a first level, I am re-using the same elements over and over again in different arrangements (a side effect is that they get an interesting 'patina', as each new

arrangement leaves behind marks). The base items are the same, the arrangements aren't. On a second level, I am also combining images and symbols. Taken individually, these basic graphics don't amount to much: grids, arches, etc. But taken as a whole, they begin to form a meaningful, coherent and poetic language. In the tradition of current assemblage work, this work is evocative rather than depictive. It's a physical language that only I, the artist, can fluently speak - although I can describe it to others.

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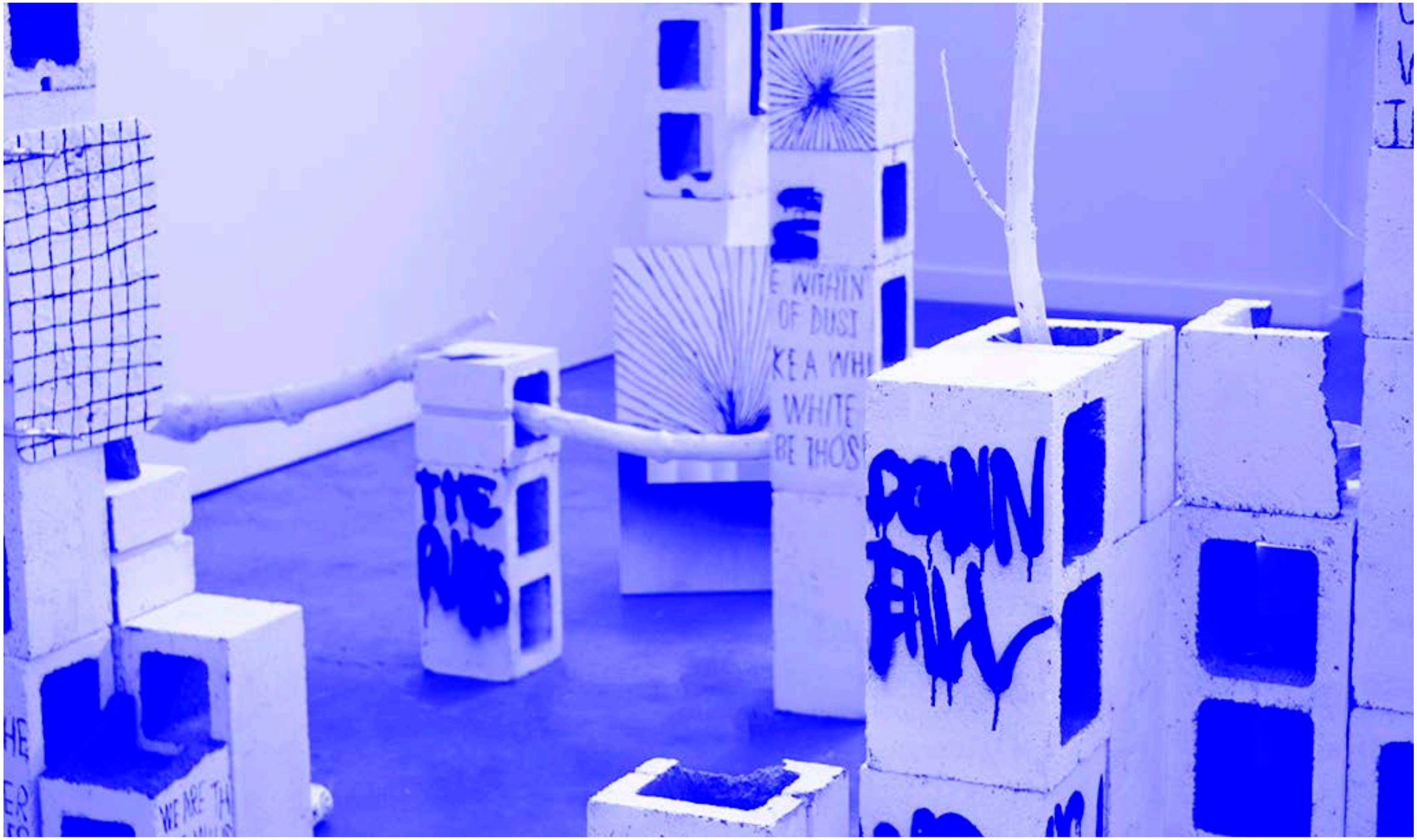
This approach to sculpture is part of a recent, evolving discourse[4]. This discourse includes artists like Rashid Johnson - one of my favorite current sculptors - who chose to describe the African-American experience by building large steel structures and filling them with potted tropical plants, classic american novels, and busts made of shea butter.

While my visual language is completely different from Rashid's, our methodology seems to be eerily similar. We are telling a story with our own language, through the accumulation of symbolic objects, crafted or ready-made. No single object carries an evocative meaning , it's the structure as a whole that does. As the months passed, through this slow continuous process of gestalt, my final thesis work emerged from the void. The result of this chaotic process would be an equally-chaotic installation, a semi-improvised collection of painted sculptures. This is *LIFE IN EDEN*. This is the first finished attempt at physically manifesting the language that I have been developing for this past year.



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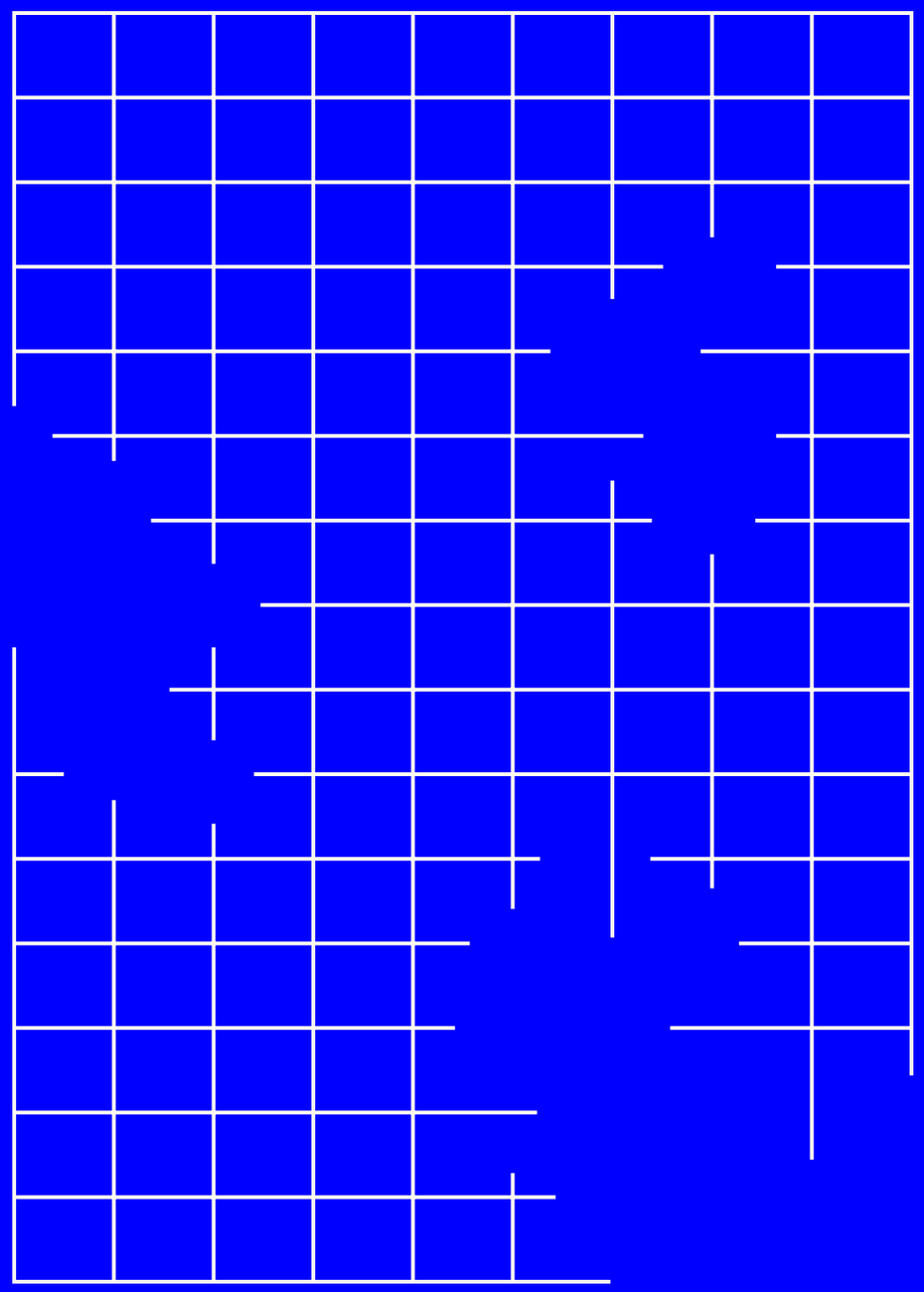

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PART FIVE

RUINS

Aluminium soda cans, with their logos painted over, roll down the floor as you walk in. The world you have entered is barren and sterile, a vignette from the year 2242. Piles of white cinder blocks have been organized into heavy towers, monuments to those who died in the Downfall. On the surface of these columns, an unknown hand has inscribed scraps of a poem, of a scattered prophecy:

OUR BODIES ARE DECORATED WITH FLOWERS
THE CONCRETE IS OUR FLESH
WE ARE THE VOICE OF NAMELESS CORPSES
WE WHISPER INTO THE VOID
OVER AND OVER AGAIN

In this silent scene, there is only one character - a lone masked man who calls himself the Keeper. He drinks a dark infusion of fermented tea leaves aged five hundred years. The Keeper looks over the columns. They are his creation, his 'reason d'être'. They are also his only company. There is no other living soul in sight. He stands alone in the ruins. A year ago, the endless war of neoliberalism against itself came to a brutal end. The Western Empire crashed down, collapsing under its own weight. Everyone knew it was bound to happen, yet no one

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saw it coming. First came the recession, which led to riots. The riots led to martial law. Martial law quickly degenerated into war. The final outcome of war was annihilation. There were shots fired in the sky, cars set on fire. There was chaos, fire, thunder. There were cries, screams, supplications. And then, all at once, silence.

West of the great ocean, the Downfall has put a definitive end to all forms of governance. The few people left behind are like the Keeper - individuals without a purpose, wandering through the ruins. The Keeper creates art out of the rubble. He invents a new role for himself to fit within this new world. He builds structures - religious, poetic structures - out of the scraps he finds around him. This is his burial ground, a monument to the Downfall and its victims. He decorates this burial ground with blue crowns and white flowers. Blue is the color of the sky, of the superior forces that dwell above us. White is the color that represents the purity of nothing - the blank slate. One day, in an even further future, the pure white and deep blue will meet and blend into

a new color, the color of the Infinite Disco.

The Keeper also builds antennas, which receives messages from the departed spirits of the dead. The dead speak, he says, and when he sits in the burial ground he can hear muffled snippets of what they tell each other:

...THE WESTERN EMPIRE HAS FALLEN...
...A DIVINE PUNISHMENT...
...A NEW WORLD IS COMING...
...PRAISED ARE THOSE WE LEFT BEHIND...

Occasionally, the Keeper also hears echoes of what's happening in faraway lands. He hears that beyond the great ocean, in the Eastern Territories, legions of men and women have taken arms. He hears that they carry automatic weapons, with arched clips, as they walk towards the sunrise. He hears that they fight to reclaim power, to obtain liberation. That they, like him, are seeking the path to the Infinite Disco.

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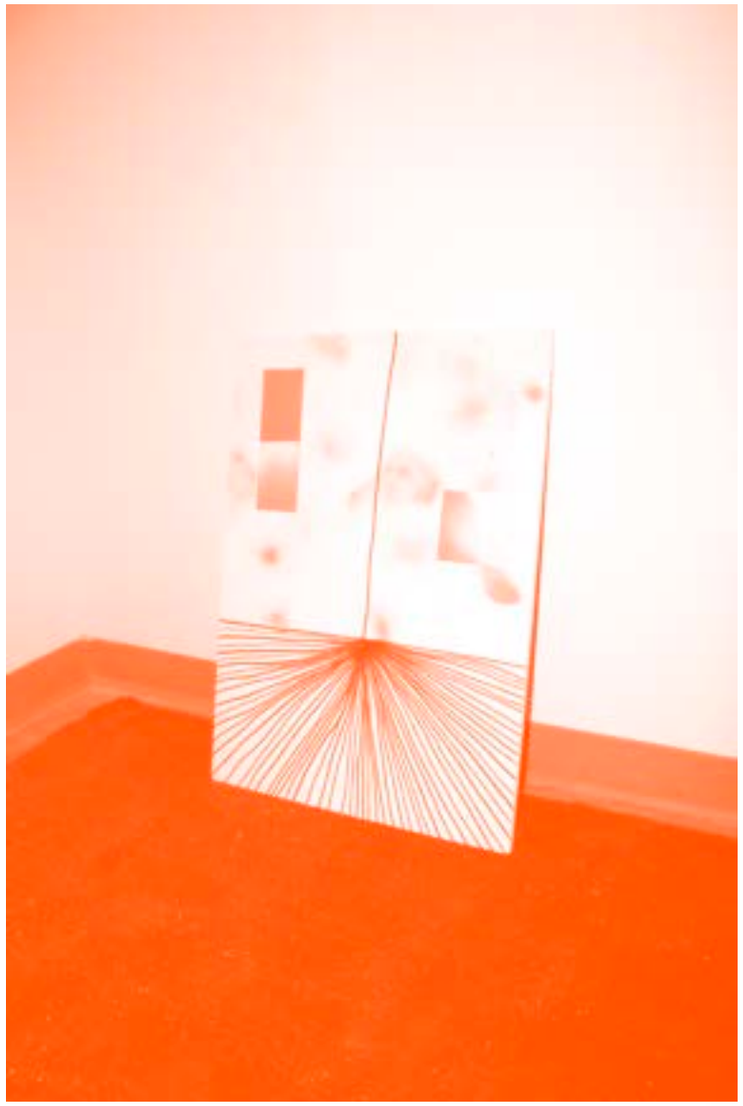

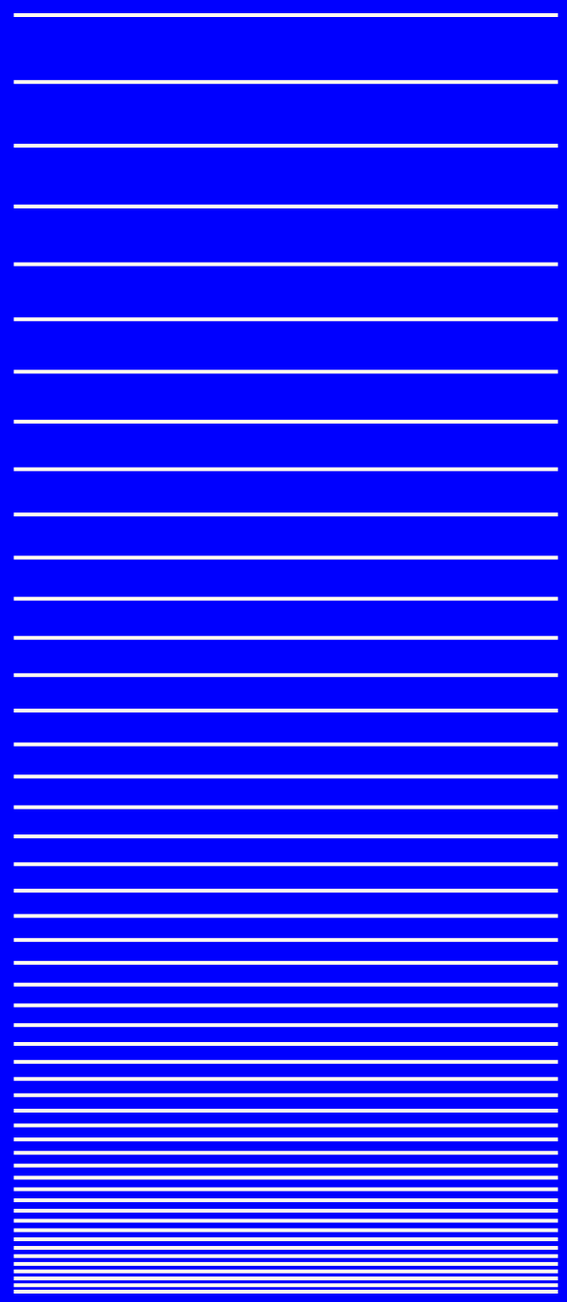

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PART SIX

LIGHTS

LIFE IN EDEN is based on a tight series of signs that have personal meaning for me, and also correspond to the Keeper's esoteric religious symbology. White cinderblocks form the base for the installation, a readily-available tool to create structure and mass (not unlike the black steel beams used by Johnson). The Light, loosely adapted from western religious imagery, symbolizes both the Downfall and the mystic power of G*D. the asterisk-like stars correspond to the idea of a personal quest (Seek), while arches represent the passage into another world (Heaven). Chains symbolize the link between visible and invisible worlds. And the Grid - directly adapted from Superstudio - stands for utopia, and potentially for the checkered floor of the Infinite Disco .

What is the Infinite Disco ? Across the speculative universe I have mapped out, this is the single most elusive element. Is it even something I have made up, or did the Keeper make it up? One thing I can say is that the Infinite Disco is not Eden. It is what comes after. The infinite Disco is to Eden what Eden is to our own world. It is the utopian fantasy of an utopian fantasy. It represents the end of History - the true end, not Fukuyama's.

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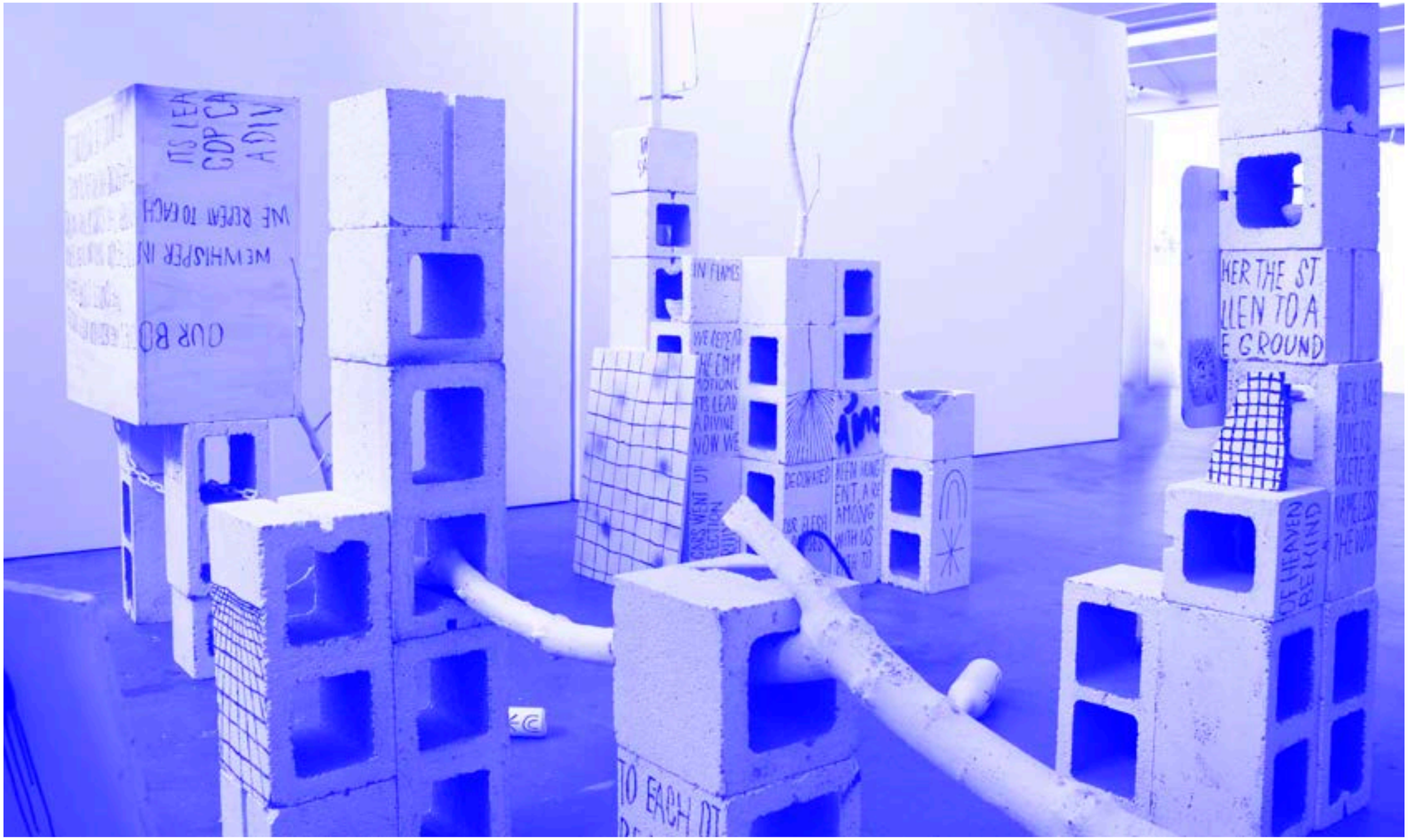
The Infinite Disco is the final collapse that comes after everything else has collapsed. The collapse of time & space. The collapse of life & death[5]. When everything has collapsed- and I mean everything, in the most literal sense - the only thing left is the Infinite Disco. Strobe lights shine from every direction, casting shadows onto the floor's infinite grid pattern. The sky is an impossibly deep, impossibly light blue - an absurd shade that does not exist yet. All of us are here in the Infinite Disco, not alive but not dead, and we are all dressed in white. A repetitive techno beat plays on a loop, for eternity. We dance.



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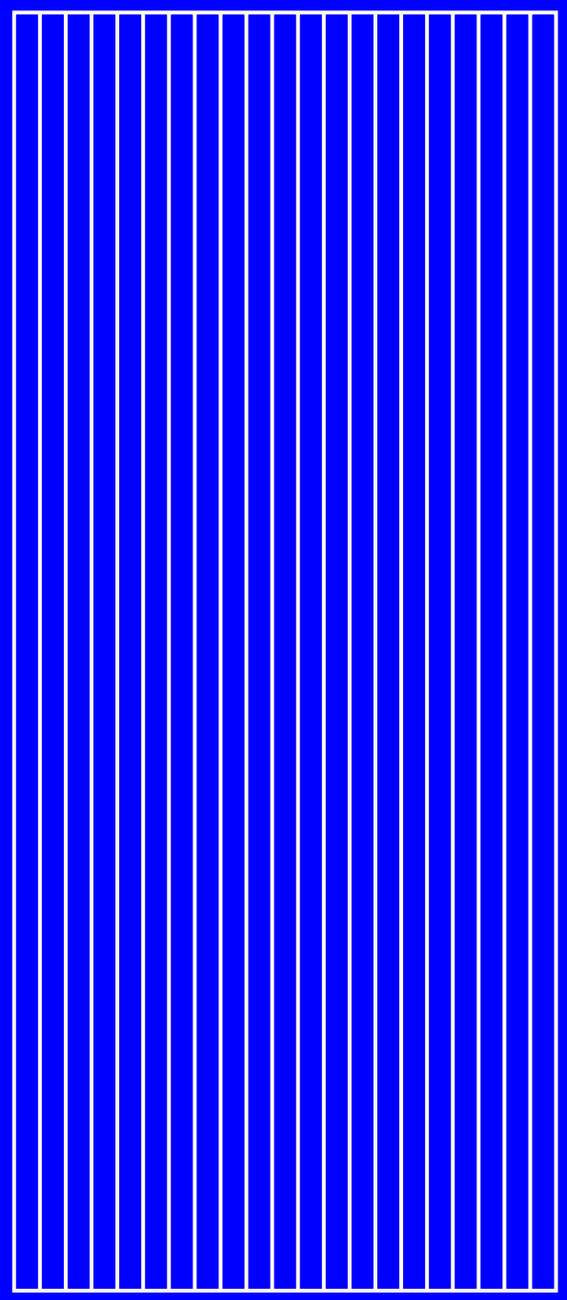

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PART SEVEN

TOWERS

The cover of Hippie Modernism betrays the ending of the book - every utopian attempt at a new world, from Drop city to Supersurface, has ended in collapse or abandonment. Art did not change the world. I have learned from these historical examples, and I take a different approach. The utopia I create is no masterplan. It contains no call to action, no recipe for change. A handful of painted cinder blocks won't spark a political revolution. Art, I came to understand, is not the appropriate weapon to destroy the western neo-liberal hegemony.
But art might prevent it from destroying me.

Late in the year, when this thesis paper was already well underway, I encountered the work of one more artist: Simon Rodia, a man famous for building the Watts Towers. His story immediately captured my attention. You see, Simon was not destined to be a famous artist. He was an uneducated Italian immigrant, who spent his life working construction jobs in the LA area after a messy divorce had left him estranged from his family. "I was one of the bad men in the United States," he recalls in an interview. "I was drunk all the time, always drinking."

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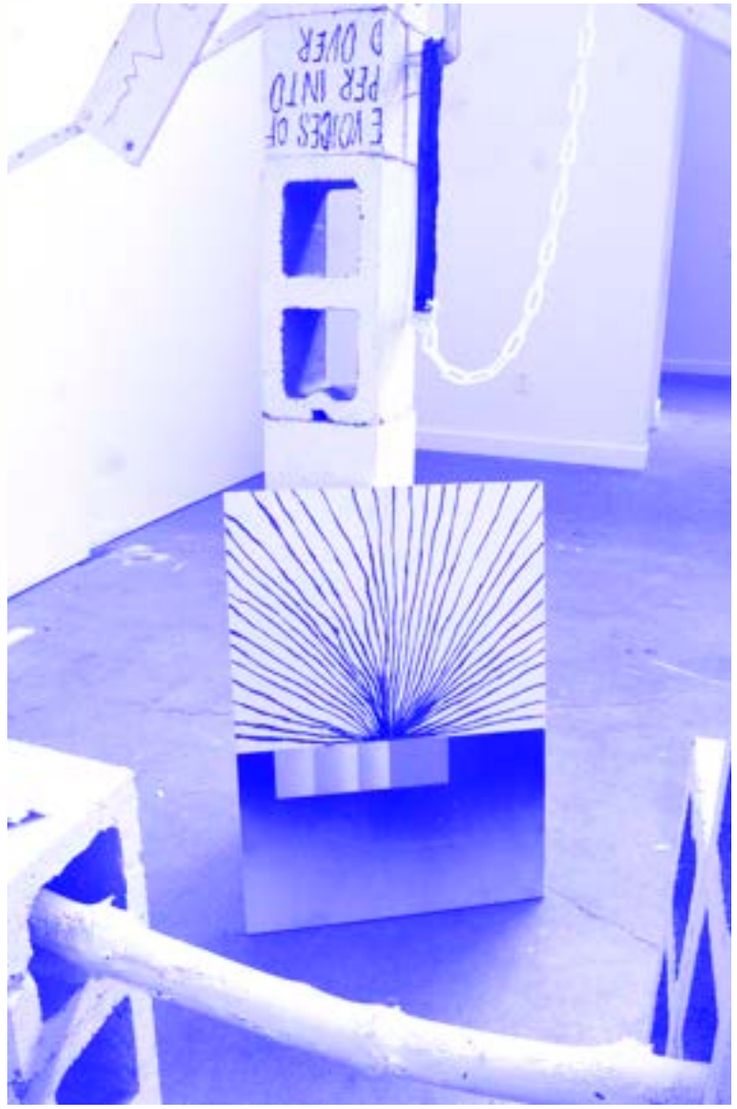
Simon is forty-two when, without heavy equipment and without any sketches, he suddenly begins to dig into the ground of his backyard. What goes on in his head at that moment, only he knows: he is digging the foundations of his first tower, the first of seventeen. The material for the towers is a home-made recipe of steel rebars (which he bent without tools, using nearby railroad tracks), wire mesh, and mortar. Each of them is erected without plans: Simon just builds vertically, making up the form on the go, strengthening the structure as needed. As the towers grow in height he starts working in the air, equipped with nothing but a window washer's belt-and-buckle and a bucket full of his tools. Eventually, he also begins to work on a surrounding garden; the garden features walls, gates, a gazebo, and a dozen standalone sculptures all made with the same improvised techniques. To beautify his work, Simon decides to cover all of it in elaborate multi-colored mosaics - salvaging bits of seashells, broken plates, empty bottles, shattered mirrors, and much more. Every day after work, he would go back to his home and progress on his masterpiece. He did so for thirty



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years, until he could no longer stand up. By the time of his death, the Watts Towers were a Los Angeles landmark. And Simon Rodia was a folk legend.

Nobody can quite tell what pushed Simon Rodia to wake up one day and start digging holes in his backyard. Even as the Watts Towers were becoming the pride of his neighborhood[6], he never went looking for any art patronage that could provide better tools or materials. What he was motivated by, it seems to me, is a purely personal search for meaning. In his own words: “You gotta build something big. You gotta do somethin' they never got 'em in the world.” These are words I relate to. Rodia may have lived a very different life from the professional designers of Superstudio, but he too was trying to build his paradise on Earth. Art historians note that the towers’ shape and style heavily recalls the ceremonial towers paraded in Rodia’s Italian hometown . One of the sculptures in the garden was a large ship, pointed toward the sea. Simon wanted what I wanted - a way out.

Rodia's motivations, then, are made evident. Within a world where he felt insignificant, his only goal was to make something that mattered - meaningful, poetic, and most importantly, entirely his. Like Simon Rodia, I may never have a true way out. But like the Watts Towers, *LIFE IN EDEN* is my attempt at carving my own space in the world. Instead of settling for apathy, I went and built an alternative world, Eden.

Eden, both as a piece of science-fiction and as a sculptural installation, is a counter-paradigm to the world I was brought up in. This thesis work is the real weapon against western neoliberal hegemony. Today, the hegemony has successfully been defeated inside of my own head. Tomorrow, who knows ?

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They say, in heaven
Love comes first
We'll make heaven
A place on Earth

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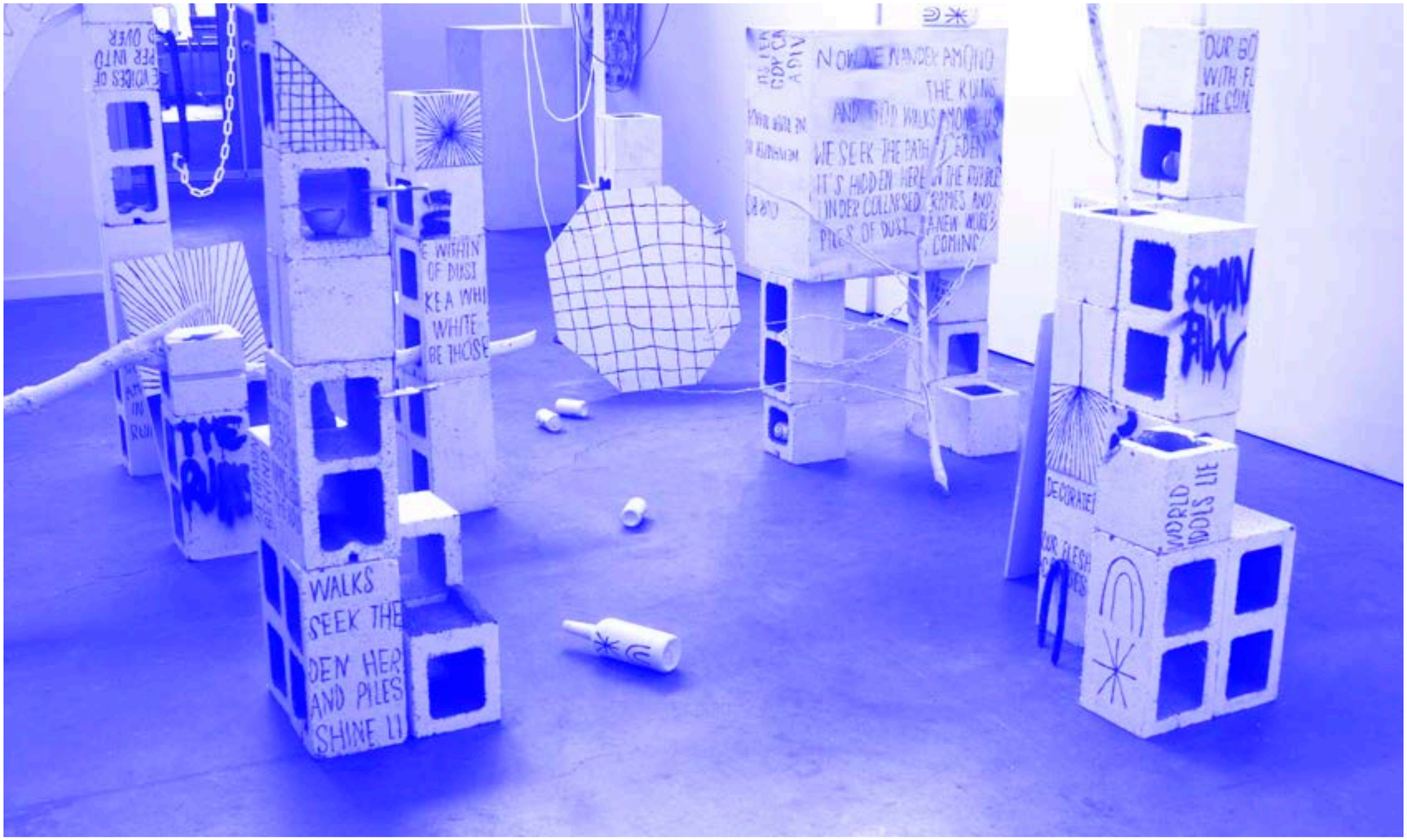

INSTALLATION SHOT

INSTALLATION SHOT

NOTES

1 *Originally from Seed of Time (1994). The quote became very popular in the youth culture 'memeplex' after Mark Fisher referenced it in his influential book Capitalist Realism: Is There No Alternative ? (2009).*

2 *Tiqqun is a French anonymous collective of marxists and anarchist writers publishing very actively in the early 2000s. Their writing deals with left-wing revolt and revolution as it exists - or can exist - in the 21st Century. They are, I should note, a big influence on my political beliefs. Many of their texts were later translated by MIT Press, and became major books in contemporary philosophy.*

3 *I later learned that this geodesic dome, 20-stories-tall, was designed by Buckminster Fuller for the 1967 World Exhibition. Ten years later, it caught on fire and burned to the ground. Andrew Blauvelt, who edited the book, says: "Well, when the dome burned in 1976, the bicentennial of the United States, it seemed to signify the end of the countercultural era. All those dreams go up in flames. Or do they?"*

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4 *The book Unmonumental: The object in the 21st Century, which catalogue such assemblage work, was a big reference throughout my thesis year.*

5 *The Infinite Disco, as a concept, is heavily influenced by my Jewish beliefs. According to Jewish mysticism, the year 6000 is the predicted beginning of the Messianic Age - the mortal world as we know it is erased, and we start a sanctified era of joy and peace on Earth. The Messianic Age is described as an age of absolute good without evil, where all human indulges in unlimited wholesome happiness. However, there is no concrete description made of what the world will actually look like - hence, the possibility for me to put my own spin on it.*

6 *The Watts neighborhood - where race riots in 1965 left thirty-two people dead - was at the time one of the poorest neighborhoods of Los Angeles. Rodia's neighbours, mostly poor black families, came to see his sculptures as a symbol of working-class creativity resisting against economic abandonment.*

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ADDENDUM

OUR BODIES ARE
DECORATED WITH ROSES.
THE CONCRETE IS OUR FLESH.
WE ARE THE VOICES OF
NAMELESS CORPSES.
WE WHISPER IN THE VOID.
OVER AND OVER AGAIN,
WE REPEAT TO EACH OTHER
THE STORY OF THIS WORLD.
THE EMPIRE HAS FALLEN
TO ASHES.
ITS IDOLS LIE MOTIONLESS
ON THE GROUND.
ITS LEADERS HAVE BEEN HUNG,
COP CARS WENT UP IN FLAMES.
A DIVINE PUNISHMENT
FROM ABOVE.

NOW WE WANDER
AMONG THE RUINS
*AND G*D WALKS WITH US*
AND WE SEEK THE PATH
TO EDEN.
IT'S HIDDEN HERE
IN THE RUBBLE,
UNDER COLLAPSED FRAMES
AND PILES OF DUST.
A NEW WORLD IS COMING.
IT WILL SHINE LIKE A WHITE
PILLAR IN THE WASTELAND,
LIKE THE WHITE CLOUDS
OF HEAVEN.
PRAISED BE THOSE
WE LEFT BEHIND.

This essay is dedicated
to my parents and grand-parents.